

Ready for Take-off

Total passenger traffic has grown from around 120 million to over 236 million per annum. Indian aviation sector continues to soar, and the best is yet to come

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OVER THE LAST DECADE,

Indian aviation has taken a significant leap. The number of airports has more than doubled—from 74 to nearly 160. Total passenger traffic has grown from around 120 million to over 236 million per annum. Aircraft fleet has doubled from around 400 to over 800 and is likely to cross 1,500 by 2030. In 2024, India's domestic traffic grew by 6%, the highest in the world after China. India has overtaken Spain and the UK to become the third largest aviation market.

With the planned opening of airports at Jewar and Navi Mumbai, and the expansion of major airports nearing completion, the 'Summer of 2025' is expected to be memorable. This may have a multiplier effect on associated sub-sectors like cargo, Air Navigation Services (ANS), Maintenance, Repair and Overhaul (MRO), ground services, IT systems, and retail, boosting investments and employment.

THE TAILWINDS

To draw the interiors of India onto the aviation grid, the National Civil Aviation Policy (NCAP 2016) launched several initiatives: the most prominent being the Regional Connectivity Scheme—Ude Desh ka Aam Naagrik (RCS-UDAN). Over 15 million passengers have flown on UDAN routes as of January 2025.

The leasing of India's leading

airports to the private sector in the last two decades led to a significant transformation. Privatisation of the national carrier has helped in substantial capital infusion, fleet augmentation and improved quality of service.

GLOBAL HUB BY 2030

Indian carriers are now focusing on expanding their reach beyond India's borders, especially on long-haul routes. The combined efforts of the government, industry and associated stakeholders create a strong platform for India to become a global aviation hub by 2030.

Here are some initiatives that can make this potential a reality.

World-class airports: Leading Indian airports can benchmark against the top five in the world for infrastructure quality, use of technology, paperless movement, efficient operations, sustainable practices and overall passenger experience. High quality retail and commercial infrastructure at the airports can help cross-subsidise airline tariffs. Strengthening the Airport Collaborative Decision Making (ACDM) system could ensure seamless data-sharing between ANS, airports, airlines, statutory bodies and associated entities. Streamlining transshipment of cargo and baggage could speed up operations. Piloting a common se-